

*Water surging out through
narrow gap between jaws,
leaving krill trapped
inside mouth*

Sitting sieves

In the sea, many filter-feeders spend their adult lives fastened in one place. This peacock worm collects particles of food with its feathery tentacles, which are covered with microscopic hairs. The worm lives in a tube, which it makes from grit and mud. It is very sensitive to disturbance and if danger threatens, its tentacles fold up like a fan and instantly disappear.

*Baleen plates at rear of jaw
measure up to 3 1/3 ft (1 m)
from base to tip*

*Tongue retracts
when whale
opens mouth
to feed*

Trap jaw

A blue whale has up to 400 whalebone, or baleen, plates hanging from each side of its upper jaw. Baleen is made of a fibrous protein called keratin. The outside of each plate is hard and stiff, but the side facing inward is frayed, like the bristles of a brush. These bristles overlap, creating a giant sieve along each side of the whale's head. It lets water out and traps food inside.